

Difficulty Breathing / Respiratory Distress

Universal Guideline

History:

- Asthma
- COPD – chronic bronchitis, emphysema
- Congestive Heart Failure
- Medications – Home O2, inhalers, steroids, diuretics, NTG, Lasix, HCTZ, Lanoxin, leukotrienes, etc.
- Inhalational exposure
- Smoke inhalation
- Tobacco use

Signs / Symptoms:

- Respiratory effort – accessory muscle use, retractions, pursed lips, tripod position
- Neurological – slurred speech, impaired LOC, evidence of drug / alcohol use
- Difficulty speaking
- Breath sounds/signs
 - **Wet/rales/crackles** – CHF, pneumonia
 - **Wheezing** – asthma, COPD, CHF
 - **Diminished** – Pneumonia, PTX, CHF, asthma / COPD
 - **Stridor/hoarseness/drooling** – upper airway obstruction
- Trauma to chest or neck
- Chest pain
- Diaphoresis

Differential Diagnosis:

- Anaphylaxis
- Aspiration
- Asthma
- CHF
- COPD
- Hyperventilation
- Pericarditis
- Pneumonia
- Pneumothorax
- Pulmonary embolus
- Myocardial infarction
- Sepsis
- Toxic inhalation
- Upper airway obstruction

EMT/AEMT

- Follow General Medical Care Guideline
- Follow Adult Resuscitation Guideline, as indicated

Paramedic

- Advanced airway and / or medications as indicated
- Follow appropriate Clinical Operating Guideline